

Chapter 6

Basic Skills for Group Leaders

Throughout the first five chapters, we have referred to various leadership skills but have not discussed them in great detail. In the next few chapters, we describe specific skills that we feel are essential for good leading. If you have had some training in interviewing or counseling, you will recognize the names of some of these skills because they are basic human relationship skills.

Active listening	Tone setting
Reflection	Modeling and self-disclosure
Clarification and questioning	Use of eyes
Summarizing	Use of voice
Linking	Use of the leader's energy
Mini-lecturing and information giving	Identifying allies
Encouraging and supporting	Multicultural understanding

Later in this chapter, we will discuss some techniques for leading when there are two leaders involved. Although the skills we will discuss are similar, there can be dynamics that may impact how the leaders employ these skills as they work together.

Active Listening

Active listening entails listening to the content, voice, and body language of the person speaking (Corey, Corey, & Corey, 2014). It also involves communicating to the person speaking that you are really listening. Most of you have probably been

trained to listen on a one-to-one basis. Active listening as a group leader is a much more complex task because you listen to many people at one time. The skilled leader actually tries to listen to all the members at the same time and not just to the one who is talking. To the extent this is possible, the leader wants to be aware of what members are feeling and thinking even when they are not speaking. The main technique the leader uses for this is to scan the room for nonverbal gestures, especially facial expressions and body shifts. We hope you can appreciate the complexity of this skill. It is difficult to convey to the member who is speaking that you are really listening while you are, at the same time, listening to other members by picking up on their silent messages. We urge you to practice this skill whenever you are with a group of friends, family, or colleagues. See if you can take in more than just the content of the person who is talking: Try to pick up on what the others are thinking and feeling. Perhaps more than any other, this skill is essential for good group leadership; yet many students try to become skilled leaders without first becoming active listeners.

Reflection

In counseling, to reflect a comment is to restate it, conveying that you understand the content, the feeling behind it, or both. As a group leader, you will find it helpful and necessary to use the skill of reflecting both content and feeling. The purpose of reflecting is twofold: (1) to help the group member who is speaking become more aware of what he is saying, and (2) to communicate to him that you are aware of how he is feeling. As a group leader, you will use reflection at times with individual members, at times to reflect what two or more members may be saying about a topic or issue, and at times to reflect what the entire group is experiencing.

EXAMPLES

ALICIA: I'm not sure how I'll do here. I'm a little uncomfortable with all this, but I sure want to start making some changes in my life.

LEADER: Alicia, you seem to be feeling that the group is both an exciting and a scary experience for you at this point.

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MARTIN: Looking for work is tough on me. I hate going into places and feeling like I've got to beg for anything they can give me.

RANDY: Yeah, that's how I feel about it. Some days I'd rather stay home. I dread the thought of having to face those pompous receptionists.

LEADER: You both seem to be saying that one of the hardest things in looking for work is having to deal with the feeling of being one down.

If the leader is on target with her reflection, it is likely that other members can relate to it. The leader may follow up her reflection with something like this: "I wonder if other people here are having similar feelings as they go out job hunting." In watching for responses, the leader may find that the reflection she has directed to two members has actually encouraged others to become aware of their similar feelings.

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Anita, a member in a group of abused women, has been talking for 3 minutes about how she dislikes herself for having remained in an abusive situation. The members have been very attentive, and as Anita finishes, it is apparent that others are feeling strong emotions. The leader reflects what she believes to be the feelings of the entire group.

LEADER: From your reactions, I'd guess that most of you are in touch with what Anita is experiencing right now. Some of you may be having similar feelings about yourself.

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In summary, the use of reflection with a single member, several members, or the entire group clarifies and deepens members' understanding and communicates that the leader is in tune with what is happening. One word of warning comes from Corey, Corey and Corey (2014), who state that "many neophyte group leaders find themselves confining most of their interactions to mere reflections" (p. 21). The warning is a good one, because, in many instances, the use of reflection does not cause members to delve more deeply into the discussion at hand.

Clarification and Questioning

Several authors have discussed clarification and questioning as necessary group leadership skills (Corey, Corey, & Corey, 2014; Posthuma, 2002; Trotzer, 2006). Often, the leader finds it necessary to help members clarify their statements. Clarification may be done for the benefit of the entire group or for the speaker's benefit—that is, to help the member become more aware of what he or she is trying to say. There are several techniques for clarification that you may find useful: questioning, restating, and using other members to clarify.

■ EXAMPLES

STAN: I don't think we should accept the proposal. It has too many hidden agendas.

LEADER: Stan, can you tell us a little more about what you mean by that?

Here the leader is attempting to clarify by gathering more information. He is using an open-ended question to encourage the member to clarify his statement.



ELLEN: There are times when I think I'm going crazy, and yet I know I'm just off balance because of my wanting a divorce. My mom says, "What about the kids?" Carla, my 8-year-old, was crying last night. It's my life, though! I have got to get out. I don't know how my husband will make it.

LEADER: Ellen, you've just said a lot. I'd like to try to clarify how you might be feeling at this point—do tell me if I am off base. There is a part of you that says this divorce is right, and then there is a part of you that says, "Maybe I'm being selfish." Perhaps the rest of you may want to ask yourselves if you have some conflicting views about some current issue of yours.

In this example, rather than questioning further, the leader has taken jumbled information presented by a member and used a statement to reorder it in an attempt to clarify the key issues. This clarification helps Ellen and the others become more aware of what can now be worked on. We cannot emphasize enough the importance of clarification. If a member's thoughts are vague, confusing, or incomplete—as they often are in moments of stress—the rest of the members may have difficulty understanding her. As a result, some members will lose interest, and their minds will start to wander.



DANNY: I want a dog, but my mom says no. I know it'd be good for me. She says I wouldn't take care of it—like the rabbit. But I was only 8 then, and I'm 11 now. I know I'd do better in school. I wish my mom wasn't so mean to me.

LEADER: Does anyone think they know how Danny is feeling about his mom and about having a pet?

SALLY: I think I do. Danny is lonely sometimes and feels like having a pet friend would help him. By having a dog, he would have someone to talk to and play with, and that would help him feel better. Then he would do better in school. He says he thinks his mom is mean, but I think he knows she's not—she just doesn't want to take care of the dog. She's probably like my mom and feels that kids are enough to take care of.

LEADER: That sounds right, Sally. Danny, how did it sound to you?

The method of using a member serves the dual purpose of clarifying what the member is saying and also involving other group members, thus generating interest and energy.



The leader has the responsibility of trying to maintain clear communication in the group. Confusing messages create frustration and drain group energy if they are not adequately clarified. Clarification is even more important when the group is made up of members from different cultures because the chance of misunderstanding is much greater.

Summarizing

The skill of summarizing is a must for all group leaders. Groups often generate material from a wide range of viewpoints. Because members are busy listening and sharing during the session, they often do not pick up on or remember many of the details. Therefore, thoughtful and concise summaries are very helpful to the members.

A summary is helpful when you have allowed a member to speak uninterrupted for several minutes. Without a summary, members may pick up on small or irrelevant points. The summary tightens the focus and allows the leader to stay with the issue or move on, depending on the needs of the particular member. A concise summary is also useful in making a transition from one topic to another. A summary is especially important if the discussion has been diffuse or has involved overlapping points or ideas. A good summary pulls together the major points and can serve to deepen or sharpen the focus.

Leader: So far, we've been talking in general terms about changes we would like to make in our lives. Juan and Al both talked about job changes. Betty, you said you wanted to improve your relationship with your husband in some major ways. Someone said she wanted to go back to school. Margaret, I think that was you. A couple of other people wanted to be happier. Now, I would like each of you to take a minute to think about this change you want. *(Pause)* What is one thing you will have to give up to get what you want?

In this example, the summary serves to highlight each member's desire for change and sets the stage for the leader to deepen the focus. A summary can also be used at the opening of a session and is especially helpful if there is unfinished work from the last session or a strong interest on the part of the members to continue the topic. However, the summary should serve to focus the group on the current session rather than to encourage a rehash of the previous session.

Leader: A lot happened last session. We talked mainly about prenatal care. Betsy talked about smoking and Jane talked about drugs, and they both wanted to quit. Others talked about things they were doing that might not be good. We discussed stress, food, and exercise. We finished with a discussion of what to do during the ninth month. Today, I want us to continue talking about the ninth month, especially the last couple of weeks and the delivery. First, I want to report that I have been talking individually with Jane and Betsy, and they are doing great! *(Group cheers)*

Another good time to use summarizing is at the end of a session. Because many ideas will have been discussed during the session, a skillful summary can be helpful. In our discussion of ending a session in Chapter 15, we address the different ways to summarize and how to use the members to summarize.

Linking

Linking is the process of connecting people together to facilitate bonding. We also call this *tying together.* This is a valuable skill for group leaders, especially in the beginning stage of group, because the leader wants the members to feel connected to each other and to the group. By pointing out commonalities, the leader tends to facilitate the building of cohesion.

LEADER: Renee, I think what you are going through sounds similar to what Sid said earlier about wanting approval from his coach. Sid, would you agree?

SID: Well, I hadn't thought about it until you said that, but you are right. We are doing the same thing. *(To Renee)* What goes through your head when you are cheering?

RENEE: Well, I think it is something like "What if I flub up, will she kick me off the team?"

SID: That's what I do, and it really is nuts because no one gets kicked off anything for a mistake. Can we talk about this together, either here or later?

The leader is always alert to how things one person is saying may apply to another person in the group. The skill of linking should be utilized throughout the group but especially during the first two or three sessions.

Mini-Lecturing and Information Giving

Sometimes the leader needs to provide information to the group. In educational groups, the leader is often the person who is providing the expertise on subjects such as diet, health, birth control methods, or types of post-secondary education. In situations where you are the "expert," you want to do several things when giving a mini-lecture:

- Make it interesting.
- Make it relevant.
- Make sure you have considered cultural and gender differences.
- Make it short (usually no more than 5–8 minutes).
- Make it energizing.
- Make sure you have current, correct, and objective information.

Giving information enables members to learn from the leader and from the discussion that follows. By keeping the comments relatively short, the leader provides good

information without turning the group into a class. The key to successful mini-lecturing is to briefly provide new and interesting ideas. Very often, beginning leaders are afraid to give any information or will give boring mini-lectures. A good leader has to have good things to say. In discussion, educational, and task groups, it is important that the leader be well informed about the subject. In growth or counseling groups, the skilled leader needs to have information on all kinds of topics, such as guilt, marital affairs, children, the value of hobbies and pets, and so forth. In almost any group, there are times during a session when a 2- or 3-minute lecture on some subject will help focus the group, deepen the focus, or simply help members understand something about which they are confused. Providing information is helpful in many groups, and the skilled leader not only has beneficial things to say, but knows when and how to say them.

■ EXAMPLE

The focus of this group is marital enrichment for young couples who have been married less than 2 years. In the second session, a member asks a question.

SAM: Can marriages go smoothly without working so hard? When does it get easy?

LEADER: That is a great question. Let me comment on that. Most marriages require work, especially during the first couple of years as the partners get to know each other in a different way. Also, differences continue to emerge that have to be discussed. Having to work hard during these first 2 years does not mean it is not a good marriage. Let me tell you three or four ways that each of you can benefit from working on your marriage now.... *(Leader talks for a couple more minutes)*

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Encouraging and Supporting

Because you are interested in the helping professions, you have most likely already learned to provide encouragement and support to others. As a group leader, this ability will be especially important in helping members deal with the anxiety of a new situation and sharing their ideas or personal feelings with others. Members are often concerned with how they will appear to others and sometimes fear they will say something "wrong" or "stupid" in the group. In growth or therapy groups, members sometimes fear they will reveal something about themselves that they will later regret. The skilled leader must take the initiative in providing support and encouragement that will help put members at ease (Gladding, 2012). Acknowledging that some discomfort is normal often eases members' anxiety. For example, a leader might make an encouraging statement, such as, "People in groups may feel a little nervous. That feeling usually goes away as they get to know each other better and learn more of what the group is about."

In addition to the content of what you say, it is important that you communicate your support with warmth in your voice, a pleasant facial expression, and an "open" posture. Your encouragement must be genuine and congruent with your actual feelings. As the level of personal sharing in a group increases, members may require additional encouragement in their struggle to talk about themselves. Often, the primary concern of members is how the other people in the group will react to them if they reveal something very personal. Your encouragement helps members get over their scared feelings and helps them take risks that they otherwise might not take. The following is an example of an encouraging and supportive statement:

LEADER: John, you started to tell us about the problems you have regarding sex. You seem somewhat scared about the prospect of sharing such personal things with us, which is certainly normal. I think you will find that we'll listen without criticism or judgment. We're not here to be critical of you or anybody—we're all trying to be helpful and supportive of each other.

In this example, the leader is supportive and delivers a message to the other members that criticism or judgment would be anti-therapeutic. This is an additional form of protection that the leader provides as part of her role.

Tone Setting

By tone setting, we mean creating the mood for the group. Some beginning counselors are not aware of the tone-setting dimension of group leading; thus, without realizing what they are doing, they set a dull or very serious tone. Other beginners, wanting to be liked, set a very light tone and end up frustrated because no one seems committed to the group. It is important to realize that the leader sets the tone by his actions and words and what is allowed to happen. If the leader is very aggressive, he or she will create an atmosphere of resistance and tension. A leader who allows members to attack and criticize others permits a fearful tone to emerge. If the leader encourages sharing and caring, a more positive atmosphere is established. The leader is responsible for setting the tone and should consider the following:

- Should the group be serious, light, or somewhere in between?
- Should the tone be confrontive or supportive? (Some groups for addicts, juveniles, and certain kinds of criminals are conducted effectively with somewhat of a confrontive tone.)
- Should the tone be very formal or informal?
- Should the group be task-oriented or more relaxed?

If you ask yourself these questions and then lead according to your answers, you will probably achieve the desired tone for your group. The following examples show how a leader can set different tones for the group.

EXAMPLES

Serious Tone

LEADER: Let's begin. Before we start, I'd like you to pull in so that we are not all spread out. Also, I'd like you to put away any food or drinks for now. *(Members do this.)* Okay, let's start by having different members introduce themselves and tell why they are here.

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Social Tone

LEADER: Let's begin. *(Members remain spread out and continue eating)* I'd like to start by having you tell a little bit about who you are. Tell anything that you think is important or anything you'd like.

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Confrontive Tone

It is the first session of a group of teenagers who have been caught using drugs. Joe has been talking about how he does not think he has any problem with drugs.

LEADER: Joe, it is clear that you have a serious problem! In this group we can help each other by making sure that people are honest with themselves. *(In a rather confrontive voice)* Does anyone feel that Joe has a problem?

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Supportive Tone

LEADER: Joe, I hope the group can be of value even though you don't feel that you have a problem. Others of you may feel the same way. Also, I believe some of you do realize that you have a problem. The purpose of the group is to be helpful, and I am hoping that you'll help each other by listening, sharing, and hopefully, caring for one another. For some of you to say that you have a problem will be tough.

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Formal Tone

LEADER: I am Tom Smith. I'm from the mental health center and I'm here today to serve as the leader of this group. Before we get started, I would like to go over some of the ground rules for this group. The first thing that I would like you to do is to introduce yourself. State your name, where you work, and why you decided to attend the group.

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"On-Task" Tone

Leader: I'd like us to get started. We have a lot to cover and only an hour and a half to do it. First...

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In workshops that we conduct, we ask participants to describe the tone of groups they have led or been members of and state whether the group was successful or not successful. Some of the tones reported for the less successful groups are "hostile," "boring," "frustrating," "combative," "slow-moving," and "confusing." For the successful groups, tones such as "warm," "serious and caring," "interesting," and "energizing" were reported.

Another important aspect of tone setting to be aware of is the environment, such as the lighting, seating, and wall decorations—these things can make a difference in the tone that is set. Chairs in a circle without tables set a tone different from chairs around a conference table. Friendly notes in chairs, music, or soft lighting can set a certain tone. Remember, the leader sets the tone, and without the proper tone, groups are less effective than they could potentially be.

Modeling and Self-Disclosure

As a group leader, modeling and self-disclosure are important skills. These skills are also useful for getting members to share thoughts and feelings. Corey, Corey, and Corey (2014) state that "one of the best ways to teach desired behaviors is by modeling those behaviors in the group" (p. 16). Your style of effective communication, your ability to listen, and your encouragement of others will serve as a model for your members to emulate. Your energy and interest in a subject or in the group itself serve as a model for others. If the purpose of the group involves more personal sharing, then your self-disclosure can be used to demonstrate how to disclose and that you are willing to risk and share yourself. Your self-disclosure also indicates that you are human and that you have dealt with many of the same issues in your life that members are presently exploring.

Leader: Now that you have had a chance to think about the three people who have had the most significant impact on your life in terms of who you are now, let's begin sharing. I'll go first to show how this might work. The most significant person in my life was my mother. She was significant because she supported me and sort of protected me from my father, who was an alcoholic. My brother ...

Here, the leader demonstrates the depth of sharing that can take place. Self-disclosure can be used to reveal past events, present events, and present feelings about the group or about some members.

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The following examples show two different kinds of self-disclosure.

LEADER: In my current relationship, my partner and I have some trouble with how we like to socialize. She likes to spend time with lots of people, whereas I really enjoy only one or two people at a time. I think this is one of many concerns that couples deal with. Does anyone have that concern or have other concerns about a relationship?

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LEADER: I want to share how I am feeling about the group tonight. I feel that people are holding back. I am not sure why. Does anyone else feel that?

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It is not necessary for the leader to self-disclose on every issue or topic that is discussed in the group. Frequent self-disclosure may, in fact, be distracting and confusing to the members. In addition, self-disclosure by the leader should not be of such intensity that the leader becomes the focus of the group. The preceding excerpts are good examples of how leaders can self-disclose yet make sure that the group does not focus on them.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Basic Skills

Go to the video on Basic Skills (6.1) in the videos. Watch a discussion and a demonstration of some of the basic skills mentioned in this chapter, including self-disclosure, linking, and setting the proper tone. Throughout the videos you will see many of the basic skills being utilized.

Use of Eyes

Knowing how to use your eyes is very important when leading groups. The leader needs to be aware of how his eyes can gather valuable information, encourage members to speak, and possibly deter members from speaking (Harvill, Masson, & Jacobs, 1983). The leader can use his eyes in four ways:

- Scanning for nonverbal cues
- Getting members to look at other members
- Drawing out members
- Cutting off members

Scanning for Nonverbal Cues

Leaders gather valuable information by scanning the group with their eyes. Although scanning seems easy, most group leaders find it difficult because it is natural to look at people when they are talking. Picture a beginning leader leading a group of 10 members. The member closest to the leader's left starts talking, and the leader naturally turns to look at the speaker. The member talks for 2 minutes about a personal situation. During those 2 minutes, the beginning leader will have made contact only with the speaker and perhaps with the next two members to the speaker's left. For the entire 2 minutes, the leader has made no observation of the remaining seven members. Here are some of the problems and difficulties this leader might encounter:

- Some of the other members may feel excluded because the leader did not make eye contact with them.
- The leader has no idea how most of the members were reacting to what was being said.
- The leader has no idea who may want to speak next.
- Some of the other members may have lost interest because the member talked only to the leader.

If the leader does what is natural, which is to look exclusively at the person speaking, she misses information that is very helpful in facilitating the group. Seeing members' reactions and knowing who wants to add comments makes leading a lot easier. Most beginning leaders can learn rather quickly to scan the group while they are talking. However, *learning to scan when someone else is talking is a skill that takes practice.*

Of course, there are situations when you would want to attend almost exclusively to the talking member, but those situations should be the exception rather than the rule. The rule is to *keep your eyes moving.* Scanning is the best way to pick up the various immediate reactions of the members. Among the most important nonverbal cues to observe are head nods, facial expressions, tears, and body shifts.

Head Nods It is very helpful to look for head nods indicating both agreement and disagreement when someone is offering an opinion or describing some concern. The leader can facilitate discussion by saying something like, "Biff, you're nodding—what are your thoughts?" or "I notice that some of your heads are nodding in agreement and some in disagreement—let's continue the discussion, realizing that there are differences here." Picking up on head nods can also be useful for drawing out and linking one person with another: "Jodi, you were nodding when Diane mentioned leaving—are you having similar thoughts?"

Facial Expressions While head nodding implies some degree of agreement or disagreement about an issue, facial expressions may mean that the member has had a similar experience or is in some way relating positively or negatively to the issue. Facial expressions can suggest disapproval, confusion, or some other reaction that the leader may want to clarify.

EXAMPLE

BARBARA: He really believes that I should be home from work at 5:00 and his dinner should be on the table by 6:00. I am not obligated to make dinner!!

SUE: I agree with you.

JANE: There are no wife's duties!!!

LEADER: *(Picking up on Ann's expression)* Ann, by your expression I'm guessing that you might be having mixed feelings about what Barbara and the others are saying.

ANN: Well, ah, I am. You see, I'm all confused about this. I want to believe what's being said, and yet I sure was raised differently. And, also, there are things I like to do as a wife.

DEE: I feel the same way you do, Ann.

ANN: You do? I thought I was the only one here who was somewhat traditional.

If the leader had not picked up on Ann's reaction, Ann might not have volunteered her thoughts because she was fearful of being different. Some caution is noted here. Facial expressions, including other nonverbal behaviors, may be shaped by one's culture. Thus, while head nodding can safely be regarded as agreement in the United States, it may merely mean acknowledgment in another culture. This is no more evident than for those of us who have had the experience of conducting workshops in other countries. Once, in Asia, one author (RH) was demonstrating group leader techniques while students observed in a "fish bowl" arrangement. The observers consistently nodded and smiled throughout the demonstration. Only later did he discover that they were clueless as to what he was trying to accomplish and why. If you have group members from other countries, be more careful to check their understanding and keep in mind that many countries around the world are communitarian-oriented; group harmony is more valued than individual pursuits and accomplishments. Therefore, head nodding and smiling can mask confusion, misunderstandings, and disagreements.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Effective Use of Eyes

Go to videos 6.2 and 6.3 and watch the leader demonstrate ineffective and effective use of eyes. Also, as you view the remaining videos, watch how the leader scans the group periodically.

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Tears Tears or "tearing up" on the part of a member is an important clue for the leader. While some members may break into tears and sob audibly, often people merely tear up while they are listening to another. The leader needs to be aware of members' tears because they are usually indicative of strong feelings.

Whether the leader deals with the tears directly by drawing the member out or chooses to acknowledge them or ignore them depends on the purpose of the group and other factors such as the time remaining, who the member is, and the leader's guess about what is causing the tears. The skilled leader who scans the group will observe members who are expressing their pain silently through tears. Not scanning the group causes the leader to miss this valuable information.

Body Shifts Members often express themselves through the way they sit and move. Nonverbal body shifts can mean many things, according to the context in which they occur and the cultural perspective of the member. Body shifts during the group frequently indicate confusion, boredom, or irritation. For instance, if two or three members are noticeably confused, the leader may want to use the skills of reflection and clarification, give a mini-lecture that may provide valuable information, initiate a group exercise, or even have the group take a 10-minute break. One body shift that is important to observe is the forward lean, which often indicates the member has something to say. Beginning leaders frequently miss this and other signals from members. As a result, they may ignore those who are ready to speak and resort to calling on members who may have less to say.

Getting Members to Look at Other Members

The leader can use her eyes to signal members to look at others. It is helpful to tell the members you will not always be looking at them when they talk, and your looking at others should serve as a signal to them to look around. When the leader uses the skill of scanning, the talking member will tend to seek eye contact with other group members, which is helpful for group development.

For groups with immigrants and non-U.S. citizens, it is important for the leader to understand that these members may not maintain eye contact in the same manner that native-born Americans do. Rather than being an indicator of low self-esteem or undeveloped social skills, failing to maintain eye contact may be a sign of respect, particularly when the member is unable to maintain eye contact with the leader, an authority figure.

Drawing Out Members

Another way a leader might use his eyes is to make eye contact with those whom he is trying to draw out. By scanning the entire group and contacting particular members, the leader's eyes can serve as an invitation to talk. Beginning leaders sometimes err by maintaining eye contact only with those who are talking and not with those who are silent. The leader's eyes can really encourage members to join in and share. Let's say there is a member who has not spoken much, and it is already the third session. Observation indicates this member is scared and shy. Your kind and encouraging eye contact may help this person venture into the group. Once drawn out, this type of member may speak only

to you. You may want to allow this at first and then, as the member becomes more comfortable, ask him to talk to the entire group.

The leader's eyes can also be helpful when a member is revealing something very painful. Encouragement through eye contact and body language may be just what the member needs to fully disclose some previously hidden aspects. This is another example of an appropriate time for the leader to maintain eye contact with only one member for a longer period. Usually this does not result in others feeling ignored, because members are very attentive when someone is doing intense personal work.

Another way for the leader to use his eyes to draw out a member is to make eye contact with that person a number of times while speaking to the group as a whole.

■ EXAMPLE

The group has been in progress for 45 minutes, and the leader is aware that Claire has said very little. The discussion has been about people's different values. The leader decides to shift the focus and try to draw Claire into the group.

LEADER: Okay, now that we've generated a list of different values, let's talk more about you and where your own values come from. *(While scanning the group, the leader intentionally has been holding eye contact with Claire a little longer than previously.)* Think about different people or institutions, such as the church or scouts, that have had an impact on you. *(The leader, noticing that Claire nodded at the word* church, *decides to say more about religion while looking often at Claire.)* For some, religion may be the major source of your value system. Some of you may be very religious. *(Claire nods, and the leader nods back.)* Sharing that would be helpful in the group. Who would like to share about where values come from? Let's take the influence of religion first. *(The leader ends the comments while looking at Claire.)*

CLAIRE: My family was very religious. In fact, ...

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In this example, the leader intentionally ended his comments while looking at Claire, increasing the likelihood that she will speak. Of course, sometimes this will not be effective, and you need to be aware that this technique should be used with care and concern for your members. Unfortunately, some beginners misunderstand the technique and end up using eye contact as a "spotlight," thus creating undue pressure on a member to respond. It is our experience that some members who are non-U.S. citizens or who have recently immigrated to the United States are sometimes more difficult to draw out by eye contact. If cultural variance presents this challenge, it may initially be necessary to simply call them out by name. Additionally, you may wish to explain how you are using eye contact to draw out their participation.

Cutting Off

Often, there is one member who tends to speak first on any issue or question. There may be times when the leader wants someone else to comment first, perhaps just for a change or because the talkative member is negative or long-winded. When the leader knows that he is going to pose a question to the group, he can use his eyes to control the talkative member. By looking at the member as the leader starts to ask his question and then slowly shifting his eyes around to other members, he can finish his comments totally *out of eye contact* with the talkative member. This technique subtly invites others to respond and avoids the talkative member's nonverbal overtures to comment. Certainly this does not work all the time, but it can be effective.

EXAMPLE

The leader, wishing to get members to share their fears about leaving the hospital, starts by looking at Joe, an overzealous member on the leader's left.

LEADER: All of you probably have some fears about leaving this hospital. I hope that a number of you will share those fears. *(Now scanning the middle of the group)* Who would share some of those fears, no matter how big or small? *(The leader's eyes are now fixed on the members on the right.)*

In this example, the leader is hoping that members in the middle or on the far right side of the group will comment first. By finishing the question with Joe outside his range of vision, the leader increases the chance of someone other than Joe initiating the discussion.

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Leaders can also use their eyes to help cut off a member who is speaking. If a member has gone on for a while, a very subtle but often helpful cutting-off technique is for the leader to avoid making eye contact with the speaker. Members frequently will "wind down" sooner when the leader is not attending to their comments. (In Chapter 8, we discuss in depth the skills of cutting off and drawing out.)

In concluding this section on the effective use of eyes, we want to reiterate how important it is. By moving your eyes, you are in contact with your members and more aware of the energy of the group. By scanning the group, you will have a better sense of what to do next. All in all, the leader who scans will have much more data than the leader who doesn't. The following examples should help you further understand reasons for scanning the group when you or other members are talking. They are offered as a way of reviewing how the use of your eyes can be of great value to you as a group leader.

EXAMPLES

A Support Group for Cancer Patients

Carl is talking about his recent diagnosis of cancer and his family's denial of the whole matter. While scanning the group, the leader notices that Sue's head is nodding vigorously. He asks Sue to share, and she comments on her family's denial and how she dealt with it. Carl listens intently.

A Group for Elementary School Children Who Live in Stepfamilies

The leader is talking about how the first few months are hard because of the blending of two families. She notices that Mike, Karen, and Bob are nodding and Jane is looking down. *(The leader knows from Jane's teachers that Jane is having a hard time in her new stepfamily.)* The leader then gets Mike, Karen, and Bob to talk about their hard times while she continues to observe Jane. Toward the end of Bob's comments, the leader notices that Jane seems more relaxed, so she invites Jane to share.

A Therapy Group for Alcoholics

Gloria is telling a long story about her history of drinking, one that she has told twice before. By scanning, the leader notices that the members are not paying attention and are starting to drift off. He decides to cut Gloria off by saying in a gentle, caring voice, "Gloria, you seem to be losing us. Are you aware that people aren't listening? My guess is that they are not listening because you have told us this twice before. How can we help you?"

A Divorce-Adjustment Group

Mary is talking about how things are better for her now—she and her ex-husband are even talking about possibly dating each other. In scanning, the leader notices some questioning looks and also notices that Betty is starting to tear up. The leader decides to shift to Betty, who reveals that her ex-husband told her yesterday that he was going to remarry.

A Personal Growth Group for Graduate Students

The leader has just introduced an exercise on family of origin, and while scanning, she notices that one member looks confused. She asks the member about his confusion, and he tells the group he was raised in an orphanage.

Practice Activities

To conclude this section, try practicing the following two training exercises. They will help you develop more effective use of your eyes in working with groups. Try each several times. The key to these exercises is to make them fun and interesting. See what you can learn.

- In a group (one you are actually leading or simply a group of as few as three people standing around talking), move your eyes comfortably from face to face. Study expressions and reactions to the speaker. See if you can guess who will speak next. Also, see if you can tell by the data you are gathering from head nods, smiles, and other facial expressions whether the other people are agreeing or disagreeing with the speaker. Try to guess whether the next person will maintain the topic or go off in a new direction.
- In a group, move your eyes comfortably from face to face. Think about each person's expression. What feeling do you get from it? If you were to make a statement about each person based on his or her expression, what would it be?

Use of Voice

Use of voice is another skill that many leaders overlook. The leader's voice can be used to influence the tone and atmosphere of the group as well as its pace and content. In later chapters, we explain the use of voice to draw out and cut off members.

Use of Voice to Help Set the Tone

A leader conveys how a group will be led both by the content of his words and the tone of his voice. Leaders using a very strong, stern voice may intimidate the members, causing them not to share as much. A nonassertive voice may cause members not to respect or believe in the leader. A warm, encouraging voice often helps the scared, troubled, or withdrawn member.

Listen to your voice pattern, perhaps using some recording device. You will want to develop more than one voice pattern, because, at times, you will need to vary the tone of the group, and your voice can help in that process. Your voice also can communicate a serious or a light tone.

Use of Voice to Energize the Group

The leader's enthusiasm will help to energize the members. Frequently, leaders who complain that their group is "dead" are those who have not learned to use their voice effectively. Discussion, education, and task groups can be ruined if the leader does not demonstrate by his actions and voice that he is interested in

the topic and the group. An enthusiastic voice will affect most members in a positive way as long as the leader is sincere. Often, at the beginning of a new group and even at the start of a given session, the leader's voice can be a key factor in generating interest and energy. We recommend that you listen to your own voice when leading and determine whether you are using it to energize the group. If you are not, you can practice using different energy levels in your voice, thus changing your voice patterns and habits. Although this will take some effort, you will find the effort is worthwhile.

Pacing the Group

Closely linked to the tone and energy of the group is its pace, which can also be influenced by the leader's voice. Often, a very slow-talking leader will influence members in such a way as to slow the pace down—perhaps to such a degree that the group moves too slowly. Although there are exceptions, it is best to assume that your voice is having some influence. At times, you will want the group to move faster or slower; by learning to manipulate your rate of speech, you may be able to manipulate the pace of the members. Practice this and evaluate your effectiveness while leading. You will likely be surprised at how much influence your voice can have.

In summary, the leader's voice pattern—which includes tone, pitch, volume, and rate—can be instrumental in leading an effective group.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

Throughout the videos, be sure to note different leaders' use of voice. Sometimes a voice is high energy, sometimes it is slow and thought-provoking, and at other times it is sensitive and caring. The skilful use of your voice is an important skill to master in your development as a leader. Note the different voice pattern in videos 1.1 and 1.2. Also note the more business-task tone in 8.2, and the serious deepening tone in video 14.3.

Use of the Leader's Energy

Another skill—perhaps we should call it a characteristic—is the leader's energy. Good leaders have enthusiasm for what they are doing. Unfortunately, leaders often hold group sessions at the end of the day when they are very tired. If at all possible, leaders should take a break before a group session. Leaders need to be excited about leading because, if they are not excited, the group members probably will not be. There really is no way to practice increasing your energy level, but it helps to be aware that your energy level affects that of the group.

Identifying Allies

A very useful skill is discovering who your allies are in the group; that is, which members you can count on to be cooperative and helpful. It is important to identify them, for there will be times during a session when you will want someone to start a discussion or an exercise or when you will need someone reliable to play a role or take a risk. Also, when leading therapy groups, you may encounter a situation where one member is working at a very intense level on some issue and another member becomes very emotional and needs immediate attention. A good therapy group leader has to be prepared for such occurrences. One way to handle this so as not to disrupt the work in progress is to ask your ally to be with the member who is very upset. This allows you to feel confident that the member who has become very emotional is getting some support while you are dealing with the "working" member and the rest of the group.

Some members start out being very cooperative and are seemingly allies; but as the group progresses, they desire to take over the group or have the focus be on them. Sometimes your best allies are members who are quiet at first and don't stand out at the very beginning. It usually takes at least a couple of group meetings to identify the members who will be especially helpful and cooperative. In some groups, there really isn't a need to be concerned about allies, but in others it becomes very important to identify them.

Coleading

Coleading is a luxury that many counselors will never get to experience because the setting in which they work does not have the staff to pay for two leaders. However, if you have a chance to colead, the following section discusses the benefits, disadvantages, and models of coleading.

Advantages of Coleading

Leading groups with one or more colleagues can be very advantageous, especially for a beginning group leader. A major advantage of coleading is that it is often easier than leading a group alone. A coleader can provide additional ideas for planning and can provide support, especially when working with intense therapy groups or with difficult groups. Coleaders often bring different points of view and varied life experiences to the group, providing members with alternative sources of opinion and information on issues. Differences in the interpersonal style of each coleader can also create variations in the flow or tone of the group that make it more interesting. There may be occasions when a coleader with more specialized knowledge about a given population is needed. For example, in an educational group for pregnant teenagers, a coleader with a thorough knowledge of prenatal care can add valuable, relevant information to the group.

Coleaders can serve as models for members of the group. Coleaders who work well together demonstrate effective interaction skills and cooperation. Even though this would seem like a major advantage, limited research on coleading actually does not indicate that modeling is an advantage. Opposite-gender coleaders may serve as role models and may be particularly effective in working with couples' groups or with marital concerns. In certain kinds of groups, male-and-female teams can also serve as parental figures in helping members work through unresolved family issues. It should be pointed out that it is not essential that coleaders be of the opposite gender. Many groups are led successfully by coleaders of the same sex. Alfred (1992) found no gender differences in how group members perceived female and male coleaders.

Additionally, coleaders learn from watching each other handle various situations. *For maximum awareness of nonverbal cues of members, coleaders should sit across from each other in the circle.* This provides an opportunity for them to easily maintain eye contact with each other while viewing the members from different vantage points.

We especially feel that coleading is valuable in training a person who is going to be leading groups he has never led before. By coleading a few times with a good, experienced leader, a new leader can then lead on his own and feel reasonably comfortable. Even though Dies (1994) states "there is no evidence that the presence of two therapists enhances the quality or efficacy of the therapeutic outcome," we believe coleading can be advantageous when it is done well. More research needs to be done on the advantages of coleading.

Disadvantages and Problems of Coleading

A number of disadvantages and problems may occur because of coleading. One disadvantage for some agencies and settings is that coleading takes time away from other counseling duties and can add stress to an already demanding work schedule. Therefore, coleading may not be a good use of staff time. Problems with coleading groups arise from differences in attitude, style, and goals of the leaders. Dies (1994) states that "limited findings suggest that coleadership may complicate group process unless the leaders manage their relationship effectively within the sessions" (p. 141). As Corey, Corey, and Corey (2014) state: "The choice of a coleader is important. If two leaders are incompatible, their group is bound to be negatively affected" (p. 29). Incompatible leaders can confuse the members because each leader wants to take the group in her own direction.

EXAMPLES

Ineffective Coleading

Leader 1: To get started this evening, we'd like each person to share how the week went. I think it is important to start with comments about your week so that everyone is aware of how you are progressing.

LEADER 2: You might also have some questions from last week's session. We'll be glad to answer them, too.

STACY: I had a good week. I exercised three times at the track!

LEADER 1: That's great Stacy. John, you were going to visit your dad. How did that work out?

JOHN: Great. When he asked me if I had decided if I was going to medical school, I just said I was still thinking about it instead of arguing with him.

LEADER 2: That's something we talked about last week, not arguing with parents. Instead, it is often better to simply acknowledge what they have said. Let's talk some more about arguing with parents.

SALLY: What about teachers? Can we discuss them?

LEADER 2: Sure.

In this example, Leader 2 is working at cross-purposes with Leader 1. Leader 1 is looking for self-reports about significant events that occurred during the week, but Leader 2 shifts the focus to handling authority figures. Although the focus of Leader 2 is not necessarily wrong, it is poorly timed. The members were sharing events of the week and then were forced to shift their thinking. Leader 1 has a difficult decision: to abandon the original goal and allow Leader 2 to pursue this new direction or to try to get back to processing the week and risk a power struggle with the coleader in front of the group. These coleaders are not working well together and will need to correct this problem if they are to continue to share the leading.

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If either or both coleaders feel a need to compete or dominate, coleading will be difficult and the members will suffer. Coleaders must work as a team. The process of coleading should add to rather than detract from the group experience. To have a good working relationship, coleaders must like and respect each other.

Coleaders must also be willing to set aside time to plan each session and share feedback. The advantage of coleading breaks down if the coleaders are unwilling to take the necessary time for planning. Experience suggests that coleaders who try to go to the sessions without having prepared jointly run the risk of not flowing well together. This may lead to conflict and bad feelings. Coleading requires the joint commitment of leaders to work together for the benefit of the members.

Coleading Models

Three models of coleading are presented here: the alternate leading model, the shared leading model, and the apprentice model. Each of these models assumes that the coleaders are committed to discussing goals and activities for each session. The model used will depend on the purpose and goals of the group, the

experience of the two leaders, the individual styles of the coleaders, and the degree to which the coleaders feel they can coordinate their efforts. Our experience suggests that, when coleading, joint planning may be the most important element. Often leaders (therapists, counselors, social workers, etc.) have busy schedules, and one or both leaders may assume they can "wing it" rather than taking time to plan together. Unless leaders are extremely skilled and used to working together, these groups may suffer from lack of proper coleader preparation.

The Alternate Leading Model The alternate leading model is one where coleaders alternate taking the primary leading role. Alternating roles are usually decided upon during the planning of a given session. For example, one coleader may be responsible for this week's session and the other coleader for next week's, or one coleader may be responsible for the first half of the session and the other leader for the last half. With experience, coleaders who work well together find that shifting roles goes smoothly.

Coleaders may want to use the alternate coleading model if they differ somewhat in their approaches and find themselves pulling the group in opposing directions. By alternate leading, one coleader has primary responsibility to direct the group for a specific period of time, without worrying about interruptions from the coleader. This does not mean that the second coleader is inactive. On the contrary, the coleader may offer supporting comments, clarify, or summarize when it seems to be helpful to the group.

The Shared Leading Model The shared leading model is one where coleaders share the leadership, with neither designated as the leader during a specific time period. Leaders flow with each other and lead jointly. Although in this model they lead together, at times one coleader will take charge, such as when conducting an exercise or working with an individual. Also, the other leader is ready to come in at any appropriate point and continue in the same general direction.

EXAMPLES

LEADER 1: Maybe to get started with the group this evening, we'll ask for people to report on how the week went. *(Pause)*

LEADER 2: John, you were going to visit your dad. How did that work out?

JOHN: It was great. When he brought up my going to medical school, I just told him I was still thinking about it instead of arguing with him. We got along a lot better.

LEADER 2: I'm really glad you found avoiding an argument helpful. What happened with other people?

AMY: I went ahead and told my mom I was going to work at the beach this summer. She took it pretty well, but I know she'll bring it up again.

LEADER 1: I'm glad you went ahead and took that risk. Maybe we'll talk more about how you'll handle your mom if she brings it up again.

LEADER 2: Amy and John had a chance to handle some important issues for them this week. Did others of you do something similar?

In this example, the coleaders are actively working together, drawing out and encouraging members. Both leaders have a common goal in mind, getting members to share events that happened during the week in the expectation that a worthwhile topic or some individual work may emerge.

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When using the shared leading model, coleaders should be careful not to echo each other's words; that is, one leader will say something and then the other leader will say something that is very similar to the first leader's comments. Also, it is important for the leaders not to get into one commenting, then the other, then the first leader commenting again, thus creating a dialogue with each other to the exclusion of the members.

The Apprentice Model In this model, one leader is much more experienced than the other; the group is led mostly by the more experienced leader. The coleader is present to learn by watching and by trying her hand at leading at various times. This is beneficial because the less experienced leader knows someone is there to help out if necessary when she is leading. The more experienced leader benefits by having someone to plan and to debrief with after the sessions. Also, most skilled leaders enjoy teaching others how to lead groups effectively.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Coleading in Groups

Watch video 17.1—a therapy group using coleaders. This advanced, integrative segment shows coleaders working together in an anger management group. This segment was primarily produced to highlight the use of many skills, techniques, and theories that will be discussed throughout the text. However, since you are reading about coleading, we wanted to give you a chance to see coleading in action. This segment is one of the five advanced, integrative video segments that we have created to help enhance your overall learning.

Closing Thoughts on Coleading

Choosing to colead will depend on a number of factors. Among the most important are your style of leadership and the availability of a compatible coleader who is willing to make the commitment to plan and cooperate in this joint venture. Regardless of the coleading model selected, it is important for coleaders to work toward common goals. This requires careful listening to each other, along

with an awareness of each other's leadership style. In addition to paying attention to each other, coleaders should watch the members for clues regarding the impact of their coleading styles. If members seem confused or if momentum fails to build, the coleaders should consider their differences as a possible cause.

Multicultural Understanding

As we have indicated above, awareness of multicultural issues is very important in groups, because most groups are made up of diverse cultural backgrounds. DeLucia-Waack and Doingian (2004) state in their book that multiculturalism is inherent in all group work. The leader not only needs to understand the different cultures of the group members but also needs to understand how each member's culture affects his participation in the group. Corey (2012) makes some excellent points in his discussion of multicultural issues as they apply to group counseling:

> Each individual must be seen against the backdrop of his or her cultural group, the degree to which he or she has become acculturated, and the level of development of racial identity.... Whether practitioners pay attention to culture variations or ignore them, culture will continue to influence both group members' and group leader's behavior, and the group process as well. Group counselors who ignore culture will provide less effective services. (p. 16)

We point out the importance of multicultural understanding here and throughout the book because it is an important issue that is being discussed in all phases of counseling (Sue & Sue, 2013).

Concluding Comments

In this chapter, we describe a number of basic skills for leading groups, such as active listening, reflection, clarification, summarizing, mini-lecturing, encouraging, and modeling. Beginning leaders often fail to realize that these fundamental counseling skills are also useful in group leadership. A skilled leader uses her eyes to draw out members, cut off members, and notice important nonverbal gestures. A good leader knows how to use his voice to influence the tone of the group, the energy of the members, and the pace of the session. We also discuss the pros and cons of coleading and the various models of coleading. Understanding different cultures is essential for the group leader in today's multicultural society.

■ ACTIVITIES

1. In a group or class, observe the leader's ability to use the different skills mentioned in this chapter. Pay close attention to the leader's use of voice, eyes, energy, reflections, clarifications, and summarizations.

2. Practice using different voice patterns (change the pace and the volume) when interacting with groups of people and notice the effect that it has.
3. Look at the list on the first page of this chapter and try to practice the various skills in social settings. That is, practice active listening, linking, self-disclosure, and so on. See the impact this has on the social group you are with.
4. Working with a partner, plan two groups and discuss how you might best work together implementing the plan. Consider the various models of coleading.
5. Think about your classmates or colleagues and then think how it would be coleading with them. If possible discuss with two or three of them how they see coleading.
6. Many of you as students will colead some practice sessions. Think about how you would have conducted the session if you had just been doing it by yourself and with a different coleader.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

1. View again video 6.1.
   a. Did the leader do any linking?
   b. Was the leader aware of multicultural issues? What would you do with the woman who was talking about her child being the only black child?
   c. What would you do with the woman who was talking about being the only Chinese family in the neighborhood?
   d. Did the leader use her eyes effectively? Why did this make a difference?
2. View videos 6.2 and 6.3 again.
   a. How are the group dynamics different in the two videos?
   b. What do you imagine would have happened in video 6.2 if the leader and member would have continued to just look at each other?